

Administration

Ranjit Singh well knew how vital it was to make every citizen in his realm feel an integral part of — and entitled to — the best that his country had to offer him and made sure that people of different castes, creeds and religions were encouraged to assemble together to celebrate religious holidays and overcome their differences and prejudices. It was most important for the well-being of his state that its people should develop a sense of fellow feeling and religious toleration and have the right to practise their own religious beliefs in absolute freedom. His aim of creating a spirit of communal harmony (p.45)

“As we shall see, Ranjit Singh was far from virtuous in his personal life. He was unrestrained in his sexual relationships, in the number of times he took marriage vows, in his unconcern for the traditional definitions of morality and in his bouts of drinking from time to time. Since he indulged himself in these whole-heartedly, he was obviously nowhere near sainthood if his life is judged through these self-indulgences. But his passion for ensuring just governance for his people, his dedication to secular beliefs, his respect for god-given life and the uncompromising stand against tyranny enjoined by the Sikh Gurus — these were articles of faith from which he seldom deviated.

The rulers or conquerors of that period were occupied with no such concerns. Appalling atrocities were the order of the day, and it is in this context that Ranjit Singh came close to being a saint. No conqueror ever established a regime as humane as his. He built up his power with a very small percentage of people of the Sikh faith and without the customary barbarities which the victors of that or indeed many another age visited on those of other religious beliefs who were subjugated. He conducted himself civilly as a ruler of a mixed nation, without any cruelty, arrogance or arbitrariness, and in this respect he may well be called a saint at the same time as he was indubitably a sensualist. His strength lay in the versatility with which he combined both fundamental aspects of his nature. If he lived his personal life the way he did, it was not at the expense of his responsibilities as a ruler.” (p.46)

“Lahore was the headquarters of the Sarkar Khalsa or central government. Maharaja Ranjit Singh's system of governance reflected his own strong personality and secular beliefs. He was the supreme head of the government, and his orders were obeyed implicitly. All matters and decisions were referred to him — military, civil or judicial. Everyone, including the army, diwans, generals, governors, foreign travellers, princes, treasurers, down to messengers, reported directly to him. The power and authority of the Sikh empire rested solely with Ranjit Singh.” (p.70)

Coinage

“Little has been written on the distinctive coinage of the Sikhs. Yet it is an integral part of the Sikh heritage. Apart from C.J. Rodgers, who wrote on Sikh coins in 1881, it has taken numismatists over a century to study them. They are original in a way that sets them apart from any other currency of the time, exhibiting a theme of divinity and valour which the Sikhs see as their hallmark. So coins are a part and parcel of the struggle and sacrifices of the Gurus, Banda Bahadur, the mis/s and of Ranjit Singh himself — all of whom carried a vision of a Sikh nation to which each in his own way gave specific form and substance. They testify to a nation in which its people were at last free to practise their religion and live in peace and harmony; a land in which the tenets of the Gurus and other religions could coexist — a truly secular land. It is impossible to describe the coinage of Maharaja Ranjit Singh’s period without touching on earlier history.

The first Sikh coin was minted at a time of upheaval. Baba Banda Singh Bahadur — appointed leader of the Sikhs by Guru Gobind Singh in 1708, intent on avenging the brutal killing of the Guru’s two sons by the Mughals, hounded though he was by the Mughal army and fighting one battle after another with them, unfazed nevertheless — struck the first Sikh coin in 1710 after he had consolidated the Sikh seat of power at Lohgarh. The coin was historically unique. It broke away from the accepted numismatic practice of bearing the ruler’s name, title or portrait. The Sikh rupee carried none of these and was dedicated instead to the glory of the Sikh faith and its Gurus. In those troubled times this helped reinforce the Sikhs’ resolve and self-assurance and gave them added strength in their fight for their rights and beliefs. They believed that fateh or victory and power could not be gained without the help, blessings and guidance of the Sachcha Padshah, the True Lord. The coins were minted with the following couplets in Persian.

On the obverse:

Sikka Zad Bar Har Do Alam Fazl Sachcha
Sahib Ast Fath-I-Gur Gobind Singh
Shah-I-Shahan Tegh-I-Nanak Wahib Ast

(‘Coin struck in the two worlds [spiritual and secular] by the grace of the true Lord, Nanak, the provider of the sword [power] by which Guru Gobind Singh, King of Kings, is victorious.’)

On the reverse:

Zarb Khalsa Mubarak Bakht Ba-Aman Ud-Dahr
Zinat At-Takht
Mashwarat Shahr
Sanah — 2

(‘Struck at the Refuge [presumably Lohgarh] of the world, the Council City, the Ornament of the Throne, of the Blessed Fortune of the Khalsa, year 2 or 3.’)

The Sikh coins were minted in the names of Guru Nanak and Guru Gobind Singh to further emphasize the message of Sikhism. They also served as symbols of defiance against the religious persecution which the Mughals relentlessly carried out against the Sikhs in their

ongoing efforts to force them to convert to Islam. Thousands of Sikhs were killed because they refused to renounce their faith. So the first Sikh coins were struck to send a clear message to their Mughal oppressors that the Sikhs, with the help and blessings of their Gurus, would never succumb or be vanquished. After Banda's execution in 1716 these coins were accorded great reverence by the Sikhs. This was anathema to the Mughals, who confiscated them and put to death anyone caught possessing them. (p.96-97)

It was accepted practice for a monarch on attaining power to mint coins in his own name, so that with their circulation throughout the realm not only his subjects but neighbouring kingdoms and other countries would come to know who was the current ruler of the kingdom. Coinage was considered an important part of governance, as necessary then as it is now, and has been for millennia. India and Greece, in fact, were the first two civilizations to mint their own coins. What is rare about Ranjit Singh is that when he became monarch of Punjab at the age of twenty the coins he struck on Baisakhi Day in 1801 were in the name of the Gurus, not his own. Even though a monarch, he believed that he was but a servant of the Gurus and hence the coinage should bear their names, not his. Even his official seals reflect his deep humility and the reverence in which he held the Gurus and his faith.

Flouting the Republican Tradition

Ranjit Singh attributed his own achievements to the grace of the Sikh scriptures. This acknowledgement of the wisdom of the Gurus and his unquestioning acceptance of the authority of the Granth Sahib were in many ways a radical departure from the prevailing practice of his time — and indeed long before it. In other countries, particularly Western, in any conflict between the monarch and the church, even senior members of the clergy were often overruled in favour of the monarchical view. In marked contrast to this, the absolute ruler of the Sikh state had once accepted a sentence of public lashing pronounced by the Golden Temple's clergy for a transgression it had viewed with disfavour even if the sentence was never carried out.

It is all the more surprising, therefore, that given the extent of his reverence for the tenets of Sikhism Ranjit Singh openly flouted one of them by setting himself up as a monarch with absolute authority over the affairs of the state and over all Sikhs resident in it. He thereby ignored the republican tradition which Guru Gobind Singh had established.

The tenth Guru had left no room for any ambiguity regarding the republican underpinnings of the Sikh religion. 'Wherever there are five Sikhs assembled who abide by the Guru's teachings,' he had told his followers, 'know that I am in the midst of them ... Read the history of your Gurus from the time of Guru Nanak. Henceforth the Guru shall be the Khalsa and the Khalsa the Guru. I have infused

my mental and bodily spirit into the Granth Sahib and the Khalsa.' Another verse by him conveys this message:

The Khalsa is a reflection of my form,

The Khalsa is my body and soul,

The Khalsa is my very life.

– Dasam Granth

Ranjit Singh made the grievous mistake of ignoring the essential meaning of these words, which unequivocally spell out the purpose of the Khalsa and that its goals should be reached through the collective will of its constituents. For each member of the Khalsa to survive and fulfil the aim of his life, he had to view his fellow religionists as representing the Gurus — and in particular the tenth Guru, Gobind Singh, who had founded the Khalsa — as his 'form', as his 'body and soul', as his 'very life'. To try to dominate the Khalsa was tantamount to trying to dominate the Guru. Decisions had to be arrived at by members of the Sikh faith, collectively and by mutual consent, not by diktat.

Monarchs, since they are by definition sole and absolute rulers, are anathema to the ideals of a faith — like the Sikh — which requires equal representation in all major decisions. For such decisions a large gathering of the Sikhs — a *Sarbat Khalsa* — would pass a *gurmatta* or a collective resolution on the course to be taken. This is what was done in 1760 and 1765 when the Khalsa assembled at the Durbar Sahib to decide on annexing Lahore from the Afghans. The *panj piyare*, the five chosen ones, could also take decisions on behalf of the panth, the Sikh community.

Even though he held these guiding principles of Sikh beliefs in high regard, Ranjit Singh failed to foresee the disastrous consequences his monarchy would have on the Sikh state. He had, obviously, hoped that his successors would be as skillful as he in warfare, statesmanship and general qualities of leadership and would ensure the continuity and growth of the Sikh empire he had built with such confidence and skill. This was not to be. But he also ignored the fact that 'it is the self-respect, the awareness of his own ultimate significance in the creation of God, which imparts to a Sikh of Guru Gobind that Olympian air and independence which fits ill with a totalitarian or autocratic monarchical system of organization of power'. (p,105-106)

Although the terms 'kingdom' and 'empire' have been used freely throughout this book they jar with the republican ideal of the Sikh faith. Guru Gobind Singh, foreseeing the pull that India's feudal traditions, nurtured further by its caste system, would exert on Indian minds conditioned to accept hierarchies, emphasized his idea of an 'aristocracy'. It could not be by right of birth. 'Such an aristocracy [had to be] dedicated and consciously trained ... an aristocracy ... grounded in virtue, in talent and in the self-imposed code of service and sacrifice, an aristocracy of such men should group

themselves into the Order of the Khalsa.'!° The translator of Guru Gobind Singh's concept of 'an aristocracy' appears to have used this word unwittingly, whereas meritocracy is what Guru Gobind Singh always emphasized as the ideal of the Khalsa. The same ideal was to prove central to secularism, too.

Ranjit Singh did in fact follow the injunction of Guru Gobind Singh by creating a meritocracy based on virtue and talent and dedication. However, the distinction between an aristocracy defined not by 'right of birth' but by its 'self-imposed code of service and sacrifice' is soon lost when upstarts with unearned titles of princes and such usurp the rights of those who have virtue and talent but are humble by birth. This is precisely what happened after Ranjit Singh's death, and it is not surprising that the Khalsa started to revolt:

*The Khalsa is never a satellite to another power,
they are either fully sovereign or
in a state of war and rebellion.
A subservient coexistence they never accept.
To be fully sovereign and autonomous is
their first and last demand. – Rattan Singh Bhangu, Pracin Panth Prakas (1841)*

Conclusion

Ranjit Singh himself was in part responsible for the destruction of the edifice he had so energetically and enthusiastically built. He failed to assess the far-reaching implications of founding a monarchy, whose creation was in stark contradiction to the fundamental tenets of the Khalsa. The commonwealth of the Khalsa was founded on republican tradition, with no place for any hierarchies. In it everyone was equal in the eyes of God and by definition equal in the eyes of each other. Equality was the corner-stone of the faith: its inspiration, strength, source of self-renewal, its essential dynamic.

The monarchy established by Ranjit Singh weakened the Sikh faith. The very concept of monarchical rule was anathema to the Sikhs because it signified the dictates of a paramount power, and paramountcy was alien to the concept of the Khalsa. As a self-assertive people, the Sikhs could be contentious, and when a medley of aspiring individuals laid claim to power at the Lahore Durbar after Ranjit Singh's death, contentions multiplied and spawned conspiracies, attempted coups and conflicts within the backbone of the state, the army.

Ranjit Singh, with his rare insights into men and his extraordinary qualities of leadership, handled his monarchy with the same flair as he did the many different roles he played in life, but those who came after him possessed none of his genius. The wasting of his legacy was a very great loss to his successors and all Sikhs, because they produced a leader such as rarely emerges in the galaxy of great leaders" (p.135)